

Lecture 1: The Hebrew Bible

God's Call and the Covenant with Israel

- Biblical Religion:
 - Grounded upon the experience of God's presence, biblical religion transforms the lives of individuals and groups.
 - This encounter with a reality beyond themselves, with which humans can communicate, is the essence of biblical religion and constitutes the foundation of Judaism and Christianity.
 - The Bible tells the story of Israel's relationship with its God, YHWH, revealing how He chose a group of tribes to receive His revelation and how they responded to Him.

The Covenant Tradition

- YHWH's Revelation:
 - YHWH revealed His name to Moses at the burning bush, instructing Moses to free the people from the Egyptians.
 - The name revealed was "ehyeh asher ehyeh," which has been translated as "I am who I am," meaning He is the being who will be eternally present to His people.
- Significance of the Covenant:
 - The decision to enter into the covenantal relationship was a significant moment in Israelite history, leading to a unique religious consciousness.
 - For Jews, the Exodus from Egypt became the central event in their religious history.
 - The covenant is the central conception of the Bible, forming the framework in which Israel understood its social constitution and historical meaning.
 - At Sinai, YHWH's clear will was revealed, and the people accepted it.
 - The nation is presented as founded on a religious event, with its rule always to be religious law. The loose tribes were united by shared loyalty to YHWH, and the covenant ordered political, social, and religious realms.
 - Law became central in Israel's religious life. YHWH authored a code covering all aspects of human life. His majesty and holiness were embodied in the Law He issued.
- Obligation to the Law:
 - It was incumbent upon every Israelite to hear, learn, and perform the commandments (Deut 6:4-7):
 - "Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God is one Lord; and you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your might. And these words, which I command you this day, shall be upon your heart; and you shall teach them diligently to your children."
- YHWH's Love and Israel's Responsibility:
 - Because YHWH loved Israel, He chose them to serve a special mission in the world.
 - Israel must reciprocate by fulfilling the sacred obligations of the covenant.
 - This is the clear imperative issued from the covenant relationship. Every person of

the nation was able to understand and participate in the covenant, thereby sharing in realizing the divine life.

Conception of God

- God in History:
 - The conception of a God who acted in history and participated in an ongoing relationship with a community broke from prevailing notions of deity, nature, and humanity in the ancient Near East.
 - In the ancient Near East, the world of nature was seen as being alive with divine forces of the same substance and experiencing the same needs as humans. Gods and humans were born out of primeval matter, subject to natural processes, and ultimately subordinate to the laws of nature or fate.
- YHWH's Transcendence:
 - YHWH was conceived by Israel as the absolutely transcendent Lord of the universe, beyond nature and completely other than man. He was independent of natural processes and could not be controlled by magic.
 - If Israel fulfilled its side of the covenantal relationship, history would progress towards its ultimate goal. If Israel failed, the divine plan would be frustrated, and God's instrument subject to chastisement and punishment.

Israel and the Covenant

- Fulfillment and Defection:
 - Biblical history records successive fulfillments and defections, reflecting the faithfulness and waywardness of the people, and the resulting social order or disorder.
 - The idea of YHWH being the only transcendent Lord developed over many centuries. Until Jeremiah and Ezekiel (circa 620-587 B.C.E.), the Israelites were essentially monolatrist, meaning YHWH was their primary god, but they believed other gods existed for other people.

Historical Evolution

- Judges and Monarchy:
 - Under Joshua, the Israelites conquered Canaan around 1200 B.C.E., renewing the covenant at Shechem and forming a confederacy based on the covenant agreement.
 - The judges were believed to be graced with the spirit of YHWH, leading the tribes to victory in holy wars. The ideal form of Israelite communal life was closely realized during this period with common faith and worship. However, tension between the ideal and the real was constant, and resistance to God's commands persisted.
- Monarchy:
 - The institution of monarchy introduced tension between divine and human order, as a human ruler was placed over YHWH's people, threatening the covenant society (I

Sam 8:7).

- Saul was anointed as the first king around 1020 B.C.E., followed by David around 1000 B.C.E., who was considered the prototype of all great kings, leading Israel to its largest empire.
- The covenant with David (II Sam 7 and Psalm 89), like the covenant with Abraham (Gen. 12), is a covenant of grace rather than law, focusing on God's allegiance despite any transgressions.
- Kingship and Prophetic Tensions:
 - Although kingship was integrated into the covenant, the basic tension between divine and human rule was never overcome. Israel's history under the kings was plagued by continual crisis, both internally and externally.

The Role of the Prophets

- Prophetic Mission:
 - The prophets were YHWH's representatives, calling the people back to the covenant. They battled against syncretism with foreign religions, economic oppression, social injustice, and international political involvement.
 - They called for inner change, a revival of the covenant, and a regeneration of religious life.
- Key Prophets:
 - Elijah: A 9th-century semi-legendary prophet, Elijah is a prototype of the prophet, waging war to restore Israel's allegiance to YHWH.
 - Amos: An 8th-century prophet, Amos condemned Israel's moral degeneration, emphasizing that ethics were more significant than cult practices. He proclaimed that moral behavior would determine Israel's national fate.
 - Isaiah: Isaiah condemned Israel's pride and self-reliance, advocating for trust in YHWH rather than human strength. He emphasized that history was controlled by YHWH.
 - Hosea: Hosea preached that life without God led to a lack of righteousness, truth, and mercy, emphasizing the loss of relationship with YHWH as Israel's fundamental sin.

Historical Context and Future Hope

- Defeat and Repentance:
 - The Northern Kingdom was defeated by Assyria in 722 B.C.E., and Judah faced moral crises and threats, with prophets calling for repentance to avoid similar fates.
 - The prophets maintained that YHWH's plan for history was not permanently overthrown and His promises were not void. They projected new hopes for a renewed covenantal relationship.
- Jeremiah's Tragic Fate:
 - Jeremiah, a defender of the covenant from 617-586 B.C.E., witnessed the people's refusal to change within. He warned of doom but promised hope for the righteous

few who would survive the holocaust.

- Despite being ignored and mistreated, Jeremiah predicted national defeat without total destruction and envisioned eventual salvation.
- The hope of salvation was tied to the prophetic theodicy, vindicating divine attributes like holiness and justice amidst physical and moral evil.

Conclusion

The lecture highlights the evolution of Israel's understanding of their relationship with YHWH, the importance of the covenant, the roles of judges, kings, and prophets, and the ongoing tension between divine and human order. The prophets' messages emphasized moral integrity and a deep relationship with YHWH, holding out hope for renewal and ultimate salvation amidst crises.